Age of Consent

By Peter Morris

INTRODUCTION

Drew Barrymore, Lindsay Lohan, Miley Cyrus . . . all child stars who entered the world of entertainment early and effectively gave their consent to a life that no child should have to experience. Their parents traded their childhoods for fame and fortune, but at what expense? In Age of Consent by Peter Morris, Stephanie is an abusive mother who is bound and determined to climb the showbiz ladder on the back of her six-year-old daughter, Racquel. It seems Stephanie is willing to sacrifice everything for stardom . . . even to the point of delivering her daughter into the hands of a pedophile. Can a child ever give their consent to be judged and treated as an adult? Age of Consent by Peter Morris

STEPHANIE: I don't want to overstate my case here, nor do I want to whinge (whine). But it must be said, it's not easy to be a single mother. Especially at my age. I mean, I was nineteen when I had her. I've no family to speak of, to lend a hand in raising her, and as for being a single mummy, the gentleman in question seemed to think of his role largely in terms of anonymous sperm donation, conducted under slightly less hygienic conditions than usual. The silence from that man is deafening and, to be fair, I'm not really sure where he is now.

But what it comes down to is money, right. And that's when I started thinking . . . child-rearing, such as it is . . . you've just got to be firm and communicate in one-syllable commands, and then the rest of it's down to breeding and grooming. I mean, not that Raquel is dog-like in any way, but let's face it. Child Stars, yeah? The only difference between a prize poodle and [a child star] is the length of the ringlets. With some discipline I could put Raquel's natural maturity and outgoingness to a good use. I mean, I want Raquel to be the best she can be.

So I made the decision. I quit my job to concentrate on Raquel's career. Although, as her agent, and manager, it has to be said that I'll always be working harder than she does;

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but you have no idea how energized I am. I am completely happy spending my days teaching Raquel to sing and to dance. I finally feel like a mother.

Raquel, with only a minimum of coaching from me, rally – she's a natural – got cast as the littlest Darling sibling in Peter Pan! I have taught her to steal a scene so gracefully that you don't even see her doing it. A chill went over me, as I stood in the wings, as Raquel waited to enter. I didn't even smile as I leaned down and whispered into her ear: "T and T, Raquel."

And she just looks up at me and whispers, "Teef and tits, Mum, teef and tits!" (page 3) So she grins. And thrusts. And then she enters. And all eyes are on her.

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Princess Raquel and I are not currently speaking. She'll come round. Anticipating their misbehavior is part of the training. Then, when it occurs, you just starve them into submission. I mean, I don't know what Princess R had to eat today, but there's no food in the house. I don't feel guilty. Give that girl an inch and she takes a mile. You could say she's spoilt. But if I have spoilt her, it's only because it's part of the plan.

See, I take Raquel to places that are to la-di-da for us, really. But what I'm hoping to do is to force her to acquire the taste for it. So that then she has to work harder, for the rest of her life, to satisfy that craving. I gather that's the way international drug dealers operate. It's not like I fritter away the money she's earning. But if you let it sit in the bank it does take the edge off, doesn't it? She needs a reason to get out of bed in the morning. She'll be a much more eager performer if she has to sing for her supper, essentially.

But she's become so . . . gloomy, lately. I don't understand it. I wonder if it's overwork. I'd suspect it was overwork, only I maintain a far more punishing schedule than she does. I'm the one who's responsible for every appointment, every meet-and-greet, every

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audition that she ruins for us, by refusing to sparkle. Raquel and I get into these . . . stand-offs, really. It just feeds on itself and gets worse and worse. Because I will take her in for our first audition of the day, and she'll *already* be in a bad mood, and then she'll bollocks (screw) up the audition and that makes me livid, and so we just end up like now. It's no surprise that we aren't speaking.

I mean, today was unforgivable really. They're changing casts, right? In *Les Miz.* And you can't imagine how hard I fought to get the audition. I coached Raquel into poignant perfection, with choreography and everything . . . *(She sings, with her own choreography)*

There is a castle on a cloud,
I like to go there in my sleep,
Nobody shouts or talks too loud . . . *

I mean, you know the show. And that's what I said to Raquel before she went on, I said, I want you to make them weep -- I don't want there to be a dry seat in that your when you're through. And I gave her a Chinese burn and pushed her on to the stage.

And she was . . . spellbinding. Little hairs on the back of my neck standing up. And I realized that Raquel does honestly, honestly have what it takes. . . Until the last verse. When she actually started to cry, and it was a nice effect, but then she stopped singing and just started saying "Mummy, Mummy" . . . and it just . . . evaporated. That magic. It's clear that she's not really a pro. She's only six, but if she can't do it now, when is she going to do it? That's what enrages me. I mean, here she is, she sings that song like the world is going to end . . . then she starts crying for her mummy! Raquel ruined it for herself. I was just mortified. So when we got out the stage door, I pulled her aside and said, "Raquel, I can't have you calling me mummy in front of all those professionals. Stop letting me down and maybe I'll want to be your mummy, you spiteful little bitch."

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She says, “Fine, I don’t want to call you Mummy anymore.” So I said, “Well, I am your mummy and you’ll call me Mummy when I tell you to.” I slapped her cross the face and she fell over. She didn’t cry, though. I mean, I am proving that she has nerves of steel, ‘cos she didn’t even bat an eyelid. Six years old, can you believe it?

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I don’t know what’s got into her. Things just get worse and worse. I don’t know what side of the nature-nurture debate this will put me on, but I now have definitive proof that a six-year-old girl can be a raging hysterical bitch. Terrifying. And the only thing that runs through my head is, bloody hell, she doesn’t even have hormones in her yet. I might need to have her put down for the public good in a few years.

And her latest technique? For domestic terrorism? Wetting the bed. It’s absolutely foul. This is the third time we’ve had it this week, so now I’m simply refusing to change the sheets. I mean, that’s not normal, is it? It’s ingratitude, is what it is. And as far as I’m concerned, ungrateful little girls have made their bed to lie in.

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For the first time I’m thinking it might be possible . . . that dreams might actually come true! Raquel and I have now learned there is a God and his name is Desmond Varady. [We] just happened to be sitting on the grass in a little park. When I want to sun myself, I bring her along and she plays in the dirt or something. And we were sitting there, when a distinguished-looking older man came strolling up and just started . . . looking at Raquel. And she didn’t even look her best. That’s star quality. And then he said to me, “Madam, you have a beautiful daughter.” So I shook his hand and said, “Dunn, actually, Miss Stephanie Dunn, and this is Raquel.” And then he reached into the pocket of his suit and extracted a business card . . . Desmond Varady. Director. Film and Television. And I

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though, hell, this is the answer to our prayers, he's a bloody director! And before I know, Mr. Varady has cast Raquel as the featured role in a Persil advert (commercial)!

In the studio, I had girls in sleek black jumpers bringing me espresso. Someone even massaged my shoulders. And Mr. Varady was so attentive to Raquel. And the money! Let's just say the contract was very, very generous. And says Des, he'd very much like to work with Raquel again. Make her part of his stable, he put it.

When we first go to the studio, I had to fill out a whole sheaf of forms giving my permission for Raquel to be filmed. Finally I get to a sheet that says "Consent." As in parental consent. But I said, "Ooh, Mr. Varady, does this have something to do with the age of consent? Because I'm not as young as I look, you know."

And Mr. Varady took my hand, and tickled his fingers across my palm, and he smiled and said, "Miss Dunn . . . we're living in an age of consent." I'm sure I don't know what that means, but he certainly has lovely teeth.

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Imagine raising your child so well that she responds to your demands before you make them. Imagine being so successful as a parent that you find your little ones start becoming, slowly and silently, what you want. I had been so angry with Raquel. The number of things she did for sheer spite, like talking back, and the [wetting the bed] pissing. But now . . . she's like a dream of perfect obedience. When we did our next advert [commercial] with Desmond, this time for Toys 'R' Us, she didn't say a word the whole time. Apart from her lines. It's like she'd finally understood what I wanted from her. And Desmond, well, he's perfectly enchanted with his little leading lady. He said to me, "Miss Dunn, you realize that I intend to continue using your daughter indefinitely. Provided that she and I can maintain the proper working relationship we now enjoy."

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So I sat her down when we got home and I said, “I know you get it in your head to be Little Miss Contrary sometimes, but don’t you dare. Mr. Varady can make us rich. So you do whatever he asks. He tells you to jump, you say how high.” Raquel didn’t say anything. Didn’t even nod. But I knew she understood.

And [then] we had Raquel filming a spot for Sunny D in Tuscany! They even flew me out. Raquel flew business class with Desmond. I sat in economy – but it’s all right. I said to Desmond in the evening as we waited out on the terrace, and Raquel was taking a bit too long in the bathtub for my liking. Thinks she’s a star now. I said to Desmond, “This is a country for romance. A passionate man like you. I know you feel it.“ And he said, “Miss Dun. Passion is the air I breathe.” [Then] Raquel turned up and was staring at us, in that way she has these days, kind of accusatory and macabre, popping her eyes at you.

This morning they decided not to film for some reason, [so] Desmond comes up, carrying a small hamper, and says, “Miss Dun . . . where’s Raquel?” She was hiding under the patio table, so we fetched her out and Desmond said, “Little lady, I’ve come to invite you for a picnic.” Raquel seemed a bit reluctant. And off they went. I think he knows a good thing when he sees it. He can’t stop praising Raquel. And as I watched them walk down to his car, him with the picnic hamper, and her with her little hand reaching up to clutch his pinky finger, I just thought . . . He’s done so much. I know I’ll never forget this man. And Raquel won’t forget it either.

As for now. . . You have no idea how nice it is to be alone.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier
2020 National Qualifier
NIETOC
CO State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

** Music and Lyrics can be found here*
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Dp8sYTlLQRY

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